

Some questions about qualitateness

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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Qualitativeness

The concept of a qualitative property

Intuitively: a qualitative property is one that isn't "about" or doesn't "involve" any specific objects.

Qualitative

Being spherical

Being either green or spherical

Being more than ten miles from all cities

Being a state that contains a big city

Presumably not qualitative

Being identical to Robert M. Adams

Being either green or identical to Kripke or identical to Adams

Being more than ten miles from NYC

Being a state that contains NYC

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Adams calls qualitative properties 'suchnesses'. He calls properties of the form *being identical to x* for some x 'thisnesses'.

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Being more than ten miles from NYC

Being a state that contains NYC

These labels didn't catch on. Amazingly, the label 'haecceity' (pron. hax-ee-ity) for what Adams calls a 'thisness' did catch on.

Qualitative relations and states of affairs

The contrast between qualitative and non-qualitative isn't just about properties, but also applies to *relations* and *states of affairs*.

Qualitative

Being bigger than

Being six feet away from

That at least one park is rectangular

That it's possible for every donkey to talk

Presumably not qualitative

Being closer to NYC than

Mentioning Kripke more often than

That Central Park is rectangular

That it's possible for every donkey to be in NYC

Any property, relation, or state of affairs that we can define in terms of qualitative ingredients is itself qualitative.

E.g.: *being red* and *touching* are both qualitative; so *touching at least one red thing*, *not being red*, *that some red thing touches some non-red thing*, . . . are all qualitative.

Caution!

Given the examples, it is tempting to assume that any property, relation, or state of affairs expressed by a predicate/sentence involving the proper name of an object is *not* qualitative.

But this is controversial! Consider the property of *being either red or identical to Kripke, and red*. Some hold that this property is identical to *being red*, and hence qualitative despite the fact that we just expressed it using a predicate including a proper name.

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Here is one pretty popular view that entails this:

Intensionalism If n -ary relations R and S are such that it is metaphysically necessary that for any $x_1, \dots, x_n$, R holds of $x_1, \dots, x_n$ if and only if S holds of $x_1, \dots, x_n$, then $R = S$.

Can we at least say for every object x , x 's *haecceity*—i.e., the property of being identical to x —is non-qualitative?

Even this is controversial. For example, maybe God exists, and His haecceity is identical to the qualitative property *being omnipotent*.

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Adams attributes to Leibniz the view that *all* haecceities—and in fact all properties, relations, and states of affairs whatsoever—are qualitative. Given this, we can't give 100% uncontroversial examples of anything non-qualitative.

The Identity of Indiscernibles and Anti-Haecceitism

The Identity of Indiscernibles

In addition to the law named after him, Leibniz also endorsed its converse:

Identity of Indiscernibles (version 1) If y has every property that x has, then $x = y$.

This sounds exciting but is actually equivalent to the Reflexivity of Identity:

Proof: Suppose y has every property that x has. By Reflexivity, x is identical to x , or in other words, x has the property of being identical to x . So, y has the property of being identical to x , or in other words, y is identical to x .

The Identity of Indiscernibles

Using the notion of a qualitative property, we can state a more controversial principle (that probably comes closer to what Leibniz had in mind):

Identity of Indiscernibles (version 2) If y has every **qualitative** property that x has, then $x = y$.

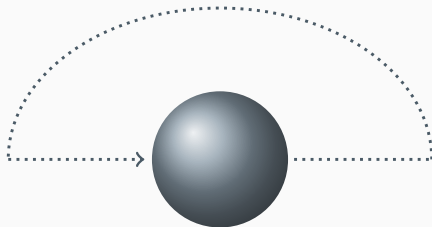
Black's two spheres

Black (1952): it seems possible (maybe even *physically* possible) for the world to be *symmetric*. For example, there could be just two globes of iron, exact duplicates of one another, revolving around each other forever in otherwise empty space. Such objects would be distinct while having exactly the same qualitative properties. So the Identity of Indiscernibles is possibly false.



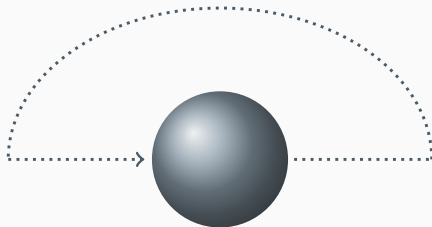
Hacking's response

Response (cf. Adams's discussion of Hacking): that's not possible! If it *seems* possible, maybe that's because you're confusing it with a genuine possibility that's sort of like it, namely a world with a single sphere in an interestingly non-Euclidean space where you can follow a straight line and get back where you started.



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Adams gives a new argument against II that we'll discuss next time.

Kripke memorably describes, and argues against, a certain picture:

- » One thinks, in this picture, of a possible world as if it were like a foreign country. One looks upon it as an observer. Maybe Nixon has moved to the other country and maybe he hasn't, but one is given only qualities. One can observe all his qualities, but, of course, one doesn't observe that someone is Nixon. One observes that something has red hair (or green or yellow) but not whether something is Nixon. So we had better have a way of telling in terms of properties when we run into the same thing as we saw before; we had better have a way of telling, when we come across one of these other possible worlds, who was Nixon.

Some logicians in their formal treatment of modal logic may encourage this picture. . . . Nevertheless, intuitively speaking, it seems to me not to be the right way of thinking about the possible worlds. A possible world isn't a distant country that we are coming across, or viewing through a telescope.

Anti-haecceitism

But what *is* this view that Kripke doesn't like? If we drop the epistemological remarks about 'having a way of telling', the idea seems to be that the array of qualitative facts that hold at a world fixes all the facts that hold there:

Anti-Haecceitism (PW version) For any metaphysically possible worlds v and w , if $v \neq w$, then there is some qualitative state of affairs that holds at v but not w .

For example: there is no possible world just like the actual world except that two electrons swap roles.

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- ▶ Adams suggests that Anti-Haecceitism *follows* from the Identity of Indiscernibles, applied to possible worlds.
- ▶ This is a mistake. In principle, two worlds at which exactly the same qualitative states of affairs obtain could differ as regards other qualitative properties, like *being a world at which something that is in fact red is green*, or *being actual*.

This is a case where we don't really need to bring in possible worlds to get at the idea. The following seems to do the job:

Anti-Haecceitism (modal version) Every possible state of affairs is necessitated by some possible **qualitative** state of affairs.

This is equivalent to the PW version if we assume the Leibniz Biconditionals and the principle that no two worlds are such that exactly the same propositions are true at them.

Anti-haecceitism

PW to Modal: Suppose p is a possible state of affairs. By a Leibniz Biconditional, p holds at some possible world, w . Let q be the (infinite!) conjunction of all *qualitative* states of affairs that hold at w . Suppose for reductio that q could be true while p was false. Then by the Leibniz Biconditional, there is a possible world v where q is true and p is false. But every qualitative state of affairs that holds at w is necessitated by q , and hence holds at v . So $v = w$. This contradicts the assumption that p is true at w but not v .

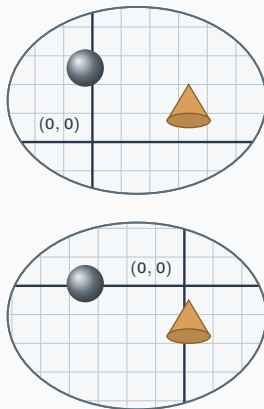
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Modal to PW: Suppose for *reductio* that possible worlds v, w are distinct although the same qualitative states of affairs hold at v and w . Let p be the conjunction of states of affairs that hold at v . This doesn't hold at any other worlds, since no two possible worlds are such that exactly the same states of affairs hold at them. By Anti-Haecceitism (modal), there is some possible qualitative state of affairs q that necessitates p . q must be true at some possible world by the Leibniz Biconditional. But since q necessitates p , p is true at any world where q is true, so q isn't true at any world other than v . So, q is true at v but not w .

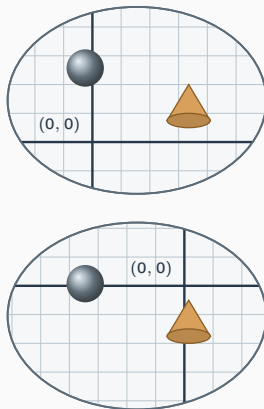
Anti-haecceitism in the philosophy of space

Newton argued for the existence of *absolute space*. Leibniz gave a much-discussed argument against Newton that can be seen as an appeal to Anti-Haecceitism. He argued that Newton's view implies that there is a possible world just like the actual world except that all matter is uniformly shifted a certain distance in absolute space.



Anti-haecceitism in the philosophy of space

Leibniz's reason for rejecting such a possibility involves the 'Principle of Sufficient Reason': God could have no reason for putting the matter where he actually put it rather than in the shifted position. But many philosophers of physics who don't buy Leibniz's PSR still find this argument gripping, and base the rejection of the shifted possibility instead on Anti-Haecceitism.



Adams's arguments

Adams's argument against the Identity of Indiscernibles

P1. It is possible for there to be two *almost* qualitatively indiscernible objects

- Examples: two iron spheres where one has a little chemical impurity; two planets on which two twins differ only in the number of horns on the monster each of them dreams of.

P2. If it is possible for there to be two almost qualitatively indiscernible objects, it is possible for there to be two qualitatively indiscernible objects.

C. So, it's possible for there to be two qualitatively indiscernible objects.

Adams's argument against the Identity of Indiscernibles

Adams also suggests a way of backing up P2 with a further argument:

1. If P1 is true (i.e., if it's possible for there to be two almost-but-not-quite qualitatively indiscernible objects), it is possible for there to be two such objects that only *contingently* fail to be perfectly qualitatively indiscernible.
2. The Necessity of Distinctness is necessarily true.
3. So, if P1 is true, it is possible for there to be two such objects that could have been distinct but qualitatively indiscernible.

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3. So, if P1 is true, it is possible for there to be two such objects that could have been distinct but qualitatively indiscernible.
4. Iteration (or '4'): what's possibly possible is possible.
5. So, if P1 is true, it is possible for there to be two distinct qualitatively indiscernible objects.

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I'm not quite sure what Adams means by this principle. Maybe this:

Necessarily, whenever $x \neq y$ and h is an initial period of history during which both x and y exist, then the intrinsic properties of h are such that necessarily, if h has those properties, $x \neq y$.

(Note that this is a weakening of the Necessity of Distinctness.)

Adams's argument against Anti-Haecceitism

Say that x and y are *contingently indiscernible* iff they have exactly the same qualitative properties, but there is a qualitative property Q such that it's possible that x has Q and y doesn't.

P1. It is possible for there to be two indiscernible objects.

P2. If it's possible for there to be two indiscernible objects, it's possible for there to be two *contingently* indiscernible objects.

P3. Necessarily, if there are two contingently indiscernible objects, Anti-Haecceitism is false.

C. So it's possible for Anti-Haecceitism to be false.

The argument for P3

Suppose for *reductio* that: Anti-Haecceitism is true, Castor and Pollux are indiscernible objects, and Q is a qualitative property such that possibly (Castor has Q and Pollux doesn't have Q).

By Anti-Haecceitism (modal version), there is a possible qualitative state of affairs p such that necessarily, if p , then Castor has Q and Pollux doesn't have Q .

But if Q is a qualitative property and p is a qualitative state of affairs, *possibly being Q while p obtains* is a qualitative property (since qualitative properties are closed under definability).

Castor has this property, and Pollux doesn't.

So there is a qualitative property that Castor has and Pollux lacks: contradiction.

How could one resist the argument?

This argument for P3 is very hard to resist. So the Anti-Haecceitist has a choice between rejecting P1 and rejecting P2.

Rejecting P2 means saying that there could be indiscernible objects, but if there were they would be necessarily indiscernible. This view is pretty hard to motivate—Adams-style arguments for P1 also suggest that there could have been indiscernible objects that could instead have been only almost-indiscernible.